

SuSE 8.1

The chameleon adapts well

The latest version of Linux SuSE promises to be more user-friendly upon first sight. The user guide employs screenshots to assist the novice, while the installation and updating software is made simple by the YaST2 control centre that acts as a centralised interface to control all applications on your machine.

The administration guide gives in-depth information on all that a system administrator would need. SuSE is also one of the first Linux distributions to add support for ReiserFS.

Only if your hardware is supported by SuSE 8.1, will the installation and configuration be easy. We used a P4 2.2 GHz, with an Intel 850MD motherboard, 256 MB RD RAM, MSI GeForce 4 MX440 accelerator, an onboard sound codec and LAN controller and a Seagate Barracuda ATA IV HDD. The OS detected all the hardware, except the sound codec, thus, we were unable to test its multimedia capabilities.

The low-end test bed was composed of a Celeron 433 MHz with 128 MB RAM, a

Riva TNT2 card and no sound card. The installation was smooth—the default option given by the partitioning utility no longer deletes the existing Windows partition.

The OS has revamped its printing sub-system completely, doing away with the earlier Berkeley-based printing system and switching to CUPS instead. This makes printing easier and flexible, since CUPS can be administered from any browser as well as from various other front-ends.

Corporate users might be a bit disappointed since StarOffice 6.0 is not included. One of its biggest problems is the huge memory requirement of the GUI. Overall though, SuSE Linux 8.1 is definitely very promising.

SPECIFICATIONS

Hardware requirements: Pentium-class CPU, 64 MB RAM, 400 MB hard disk space, for command line interface.

Package contents: One user guide, one administration guide, one quick install guide, seven CDs and one DVD

SuSE 8.1	A-
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶

Fuji Finepix S304

Good for stills

The latest high-resolution digicam from the Fuji S-series, the Finepix S304 has a protrusion on the right-hand side, making it look bulky, even though it is quite light in weight and compact. The

rubber grip on the protruding facade adds to the comfort and reduces the chances of accidentally dropping the camera. The lens protection cap comes with a string and clips on firmly. The flash pops

up like the headlights of a sports car when a button on the left-hand side is pressed.

The 1.8-inch TFT LCD screen is large enough to view images clearly and a button above it switches the display mode between the LCD and the TTL EVF (Through the Lens Electronic View Finder). The brightness can be adjusted through the user menu. However, the actual colour and brightness of the photograph is quite different from what is seen on screen. The preview of the captured images can be seen by turning the front control dial from Camera to Preview mode. You can see the thumbnails when required and erase images to free up space.

The interface is very user-friendly—the white balance, exposure compensation, aperture priority, sharpness, quality of images, flash mode and flash brightness can be adjusted for precision photography. It has a 6x optical zoom lens and another 3.2x of digital zoom that can be adjusted by the buttons placed on the right-hand side at the back of the camera. A slot on the side makes space for a 16 MB xD-Picture Card memory, which can store 12 photographs at the resolution of 2048 x 1536 pixels. Four AA batteries power the camera for more than 200 photographs. To save on power, the LCD screen automatically shuts off when it has not been used for a while. You can also record small movie clips with sound of length up to 200 seconds at the lowest

resolution and the camera can also be configured to work as a web-cam by changing the USB mode to PC cam in the setup menu.

The lag time between clicking and image capture is longer than desirable—this is unsuitable for wildlife and live photography where timing is critical. It also has a rather large cycle time and is unsuitable for taking quick photographs in succession. Three aperture settings give flexibility of field of depth. The macro function can capture images as close as 10 cm from the lens.

There are a number of pre-defined white balance settings that can capture optimal-quality images in yellow light, white light, or on a cloudy day. The sharpness of the images can also be adjusted.

This is a very powerful and efficient camera with good aesthetic design. It is, however, quite slow and would not be a good choice when many photos need to be shot continuously and at high speeds. While keeping in mind the performance, the price is quite high.

SPECIFICATIONS

1/2.7 inch CCD sensor, 3.24 million effective pixels, xD-picture card, 6X optical lens equivalent to 38mm-228mm, JPEG file format output
Bundled accessories: User manual, quick start guide, 16 MB xD-picture card, four AA alkaline batteries, neck strap, USB cable, lens cap, adapter ring, USB driver CD, FinePix viewer, DP Editor, Apple QuickTime 5.0 and ImageMixer VCD for FinePix

Fuji Finepix S304	B+
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶

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